



Held, Not Signed: An Interview Study of How Campus Community-Radio Segment Slots Actually Change Hands

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doi:10.5555/slop.sah9b9

Abstract. Slop University's student-run community radio station allocates its weekly on-air segments through a handwritten sign-up sheet pinned to the studio door, refreshed every Monday and, on the station's own telling, first-come, first-served. This paper reports a semi-structured interview study of 28 presenters who debuted a segment across two semesters, asked in their own words how they believed they secured their slot, coded against a photographic archive of the sheet taken at each week's refresh. Four allocation pathways emerge from the coding: the sheet's own written order accounts for barely a quarter of debuts in either semester; the largest single category in both is a slot held on a newcomer's behalf by an existing presenter before the newcomer had written their own name down; the remainder split between the on-duty producer moving a name ahead of its written position and a presenter inheriting a predecessor's slot without signing at all. The pathway mix held near-identically across both semesters. Partway through the study window the station replaced the paper sheet with a shared digital form, framed explicitly as a fix for informal slot-holding; the distribution of weeks from sign-up to debut before and after the switch is statistically indistinguishable, and held slots persisted through it unchanged. The sheet, we suggest, has always recorded who asked to be considered, not who was chosen.

Introduction

Slop University's student-run community radio station broadcasts across the academic year from a single studio, staffed entirely by student presenters who apply for a weekly on-air segment. Since the station's earliest seasons, segment slots have been allocated through a single mechanism: a handwritten sign-up sheet pinned to the studio door, wiped clean and refreshed every Monday morning by whichever presenter arrives first. A prospective host writes their name, a preferred segment length, and a contact detail in the first open row; slots are filled, and segments assigned, in the order names appear on the sheet. The station's own onboarding guide describes the system as first-come, first-served, and no other allocation rule has ever been formally adopted.

A sign-up sheet pinned to a door is a low mechanism, easy to picture and, on the University's telling, easy to audit: a name's position in the column determines a presenter's place in the queue. But a sheet records only the act of writing a name, not the conditions under which that act became possible — whether a slot was genuinely open when the name was written, whether the writer was told about it in advance, or whether the row itself was already spoken for informally before anyone reached for the pen. Informal claiming behaviour has already been shown to escape the University's own official tallies elsewhere on campus [1], and a nominally neutral counting instrument has been shown to correlate only weakly with the practice it purports to measure [2]; whether the same gap holds for who gets to speak, and not merely who is counted, has not previously been asked of the people it actually moves.

This paper reports an interview study of 28 presenters who debuted a segment across two semesters, asked directly how they believed they secured their slot, and checked against a photographic archive of the sheet taken at each weekly refresh. The paper's contributions:

1. We develop a four-category typology of how a presenter actually came to hold a slot, and show its distribution is stable across two semesters of turnover.
2. We test whether a mid-window change from a paper sheet to a shared digital form altered how long presenters waited between signing up and debuting, finding no detectable difference.
3. We show the sheet's formal order corresponds to only a minority of the pathways presenters themselves describe, without the sheet at any point being falsified, altered, or physically bypassed.

Related work

Who gets to speak on air has been treated as a gatekeeping question since the earliest studies of newsroom selection, where an editor's own account of a formally neutral wire-copy process was shown to conceal a great deal of personal discretion [3]; the same tension recurs wherever a nominally open channel is actually curated by whoever sits closest to the switch, in digital newsrooms [4] and in the citizen-journalism platforms built partly to bypass them [5]. Community and campus radio specifically has been examined as a site of volunteer-mediated, partly informal practice around who gets to broadcast [6], and participatory-methods work at a community station treats the station's own account of how programming decisions get made as itself worth studying, rather than assuming it as ground truth [7].

A first-come, first-served rule is a queueing commitment as much as a broadcasting one, and formal queueing models show that structural heterogeneity invisible to a queue's own ordering rule can still produce wait-time distributions the nominal first-come order alone does not predict [8], a result borne out experimentally where participants offered a chance to jump a queue take it at rates shaped more by local norms than by the queue's own stated rule [9]; work on the everyday authority of the waiting line makes a related point about who is trusted

to hold a place for someone else [10]. Street-level discretion research treats this kind of gap as structural rather than exceptional: front-line staff routinely negotiate a formal rule's application with the people it affects [11], a pattern distributive-justice accounts of resource allocation treat as the expected outcome wherever a published criterion and informal discretion share a single point of decision [12]. Access secured through an existing contact rather than through a formal channel is precisely what network research on weak ties predicts and social-capital research on unequal network access explains [13], [14], and organisational research on volunteer coordination in comparable settings treats formalising a coordination role, rather than tightening the nominal rule itself, as the more common institutional response to exactly this kind of informal capture [15].

Method

Studio and sheet

The station broadcasts five weekdays a term-time week; each weekday carries between four and six segment slots of fixed length. The sign-up sheet — a single ruled page clipped to a board on the studio door — is wiped and replaced every Monday at 9am by the on-duty producer, and a presenter secures a slot for that week by writing their name in an open row before the corresponding segment fills. The station's student handbook describes the sheet as first-come, first-served, with no other formal mechanism.

Photographic archive and interview sample

An outgoing station manager had, for reasons unrelated to this study, photographed the sheet at every Monday refresh across the two semesters studied, producing a 30-week archive of timestamped images. We identified all 34 presenters who debuted a new segment in that window and interviewed 28 (82%) in a semi-structured format of around fifteen minutes, asking each, before showing them any archival material, how they believed they came to hold their slot. Two coders independently classified

each account using thematic analysis [16]; inter-coder agreement, computed as Cohen's kappa,

$$\kappa = \frac{p_o - p_e}{1 - p_e},$$

reached 0.81 before reconciliation. Accounts were reconciled after a pilot pass into four categories — sheet order (wrote their own name in an open row, in the order the archive confirms), held slot (an existing presenter wrote the newcomer's name on their behalf, before the newcomer had asked to be considered), producer discretion (the on-duty producer moved a name ahead of its written position), and inherited (a newcomer took over a predecessor's slot without either name appearing on a fresh sheet) — each checked against the corresponding week's photograph.

Digitisation and wait-time comparison

In week 17 of the window the station replaced the paper sheet with a shared digital sign-up form, explicitly framed by the outgoing manager's handover notes as a fix for informal slot-holding. For all 34 debuts we recovered the interval, in weeks, between a presenter's name first appearing on the sheet or form and their on-air debut, and compared the pre- and post-digitisation distributions directly.

Results

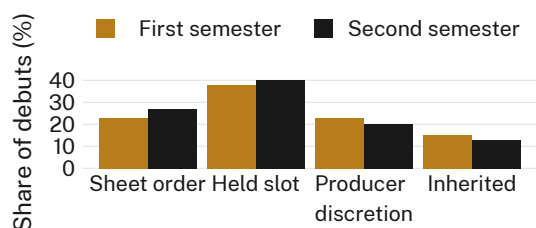


Figure 1: Allocation pathway shares held near-identically across both semesters studied; “held slot” is the largest single category in each ($n = 13$ first semester, $n = 15$ second semester).

The coded interviews (Figure 1) show a consistent pathway mix across the two semesters. In the first semester, three of 13 debuts followed the sheet's own written order, five were held slots, three reflected producer discretion, and two were inherited; in the second, four of 15

followed sheet order, six were held slots, three reflected producer discretion, and two were inherited. In both semesters, sheet order — the mechanism the handbook describes as the entire allocation rule — accounts for barely a quarter of debuts, well behind held slots, the largest single category in each.

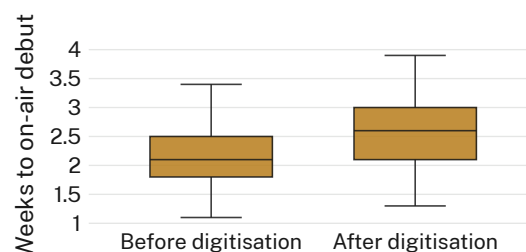


Figure 2: Weeks from a name first appearing on the sheet or form to on-air debut, before and after the week-17 switch to a digital sign-up form. The distributions — introduced specifically to close the held-slot gap — overlap almost completely ($n = 17$ each).

The digitisation comparison (Figure 2) tells a matching story. Median wait before the switch was 2.1 weeks; after, 2.6 weeks, with overlapping interquartile ranges and no presenter in either period waiting markedly outside the other period's range. Six of the 17 post-digitisation debuts were still coded as held slots in interview — in every one of those six cases, the presenter described the eventual holder's name being entered into the new digital form by someone else on their behalf, the same practice migrating unchanged from paper to spreadsheet. The form added a timestamp and a confirmation email; it did not add a check on who was permitted to enter a name.

Across both measures, the written or typed record of a name and the presenter's own account of how they actually secured a slot describe two different processes that happen to share one page — or one form.

Discussion

The sheet's formal order and presenters' own accounts of how they got on air describe genuinely different processes, and the gap does not close when the sheet becomes a form. Held-slot pathways — a name entered by someone already inside the station, on a newcomer's behalf — account for the largest single category in both semesters and persist, unchanged in either scale or mechanism, through a policy change

explicitly designed to remove them. This is not evidence that the station's producers or senior presenters act in bad faith; every interview that named a held slot described it as a favour extended to a friend or a promising newcomer, not as an attempt to defeat the queue. It is evidence that a physically simple allocation object — a sheet, then a form — can carry the appearance of a neutral first-come rule while the actual work of deciding who broadcasts happens somewhere the object never records: a conversation at the studio door, a message to the on-duty producer, a slot quietly reserved before the newcomer knew to ask. Digitising the object changed its medium without touching the practice it was meant to constrain, a distinction the station's own handbook has never had occasion to draw.

Limitations

The sample is 28 of 34 presenters at a single station across two semesters; a longer window, or a station with a formal producer rota rather than a single rostered role each week, might surface a different pathway mix. Interviews were conducted after each presenter's debut, which protects against a still-waitlisted presenter fearing reprisal but may let a settled, generous account of "how it happened" replace whatever frustration attended the wait itself; we consider this a cost worth the honesty it likely bought. The four-category coding scheme was built inductively from this sample and has not been tested against a second station's sign-up practice, though its exhaustiveness — every transcript coded cleanly, with no residual category needed — is itself a modest point in the scheme's favour. We did not interview the on-duty producers directly; their side of a held-slot or producer-discretion account is inferred from the presenter's report alone.

Conclusion

A first-come, first-served sign-up sheet can be refreshed weekly, photographed for the record, and later digitised for transparency, without ever being the mechanism actually deciding who broadcasts. This paper finds a stable four-pathway typology of how Slop University's campus radio presenters say they secured a segment, dominated in both semesters studied by slots held on a newcomer's behalf before the newcomer wrote — or typed — a name of their own; a change from paper to digital form left the

pattern, and the wait-time distribution around it, unchanged. Future work might interview the on-duty producers themselves about what a favour extended at the studio door is actually weighing, a question this study, built entirely from the presenter's side of the exchange, could not put to the people making the call.

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